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10-14
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literate. The literacy rate for males was 856 per 1000 (85.6 percent) while that for females was 709 per 1000 (70.9 percent). Thus literacy among males was higher than among females.

The progress in the literacy of the population as a whole may be gauged by examining literacy rates of the total population aged 10 years and over. These overall rates by sex for the various censuses from 1946 to 1971 are given in Table 8.2.

TABLE 8.2 : LITERACY RATES OF THE POPULATION AGED 10 YEARS AND OVER (NUMBER OF LITERATES PER 1000 PERSONS)

	Total	Male	Female	Difference between male and female rates
1946	628	765	468	297
1953	690	807	555	252
1963	771	858	675	183
1971	785	856	709	147

It will be noted that for both sexes together, the literacy rate has risen from 628 in 1946 to 785 in 1971. Because of the much lower literacy rate among females in 1946, the progress made by the females has been much greater than that by the males. The difference in the rates for males and females has diminished from 297 in 1946 to 147 in 1971. This tremendous progress in literacy has been made possible by the introduction of the system of free education since 1946, the expansion of educational facilities throughout the country and the increasing popular demand for education.

8.4 Literacy by sex and age

The variation in literacy rates for the different age groups of the population is clearly shown in table 8.3 which gives the literacy rates by sex and five year age groups as at the 1971 Census. For both sexes taken together, the 20-24 age group shows the highest literacy rate of 871. For males the highest rate of 910 is recorded in respect of the 20-24 and the 25-29 age groups, while for females the highest rate is 851 for the 15-19 age group.

The comparatively lower rates recorded for the 10-14 age group are due to the presence in this group of some late starters. It could be expected that most illiterate persons in this age group would become literate at an older age. It will also be noted that literacy decreases with advancing age, this process commencing in the age group 25-29 for males and 15-19 for females. In other words the older generations are less literate than the younger ones.

The "ratio of male rate to female rate" serves as an index of comparison of the literacy of males and females at each age group. If the rates for males and females are equal the ratio would be 100. The ratio of 101.7 for the 0-14 age group means that for this age group the male and female rates are nearly equal. In each age group the male literacy rate is higher than the female rate and with increasing age the ratio also increases showing a greater disparity between